OBITUARY: PANDIT BIRJU MAHARAJ (1938-2022)

Raja of Ras

The Kathak stalwart's impact and outreach have been and shall remain universal

By Ashish Mohan Khokar

Brij Mohan Nath Mishra, or Birju Maharaj as he was popularly known, was a genius artiste, a complete artiste. Such artistes come once in many centuries. He could sing, dance, compose, create, choreograph, play various instruments and speak on art. He wrote definitive books too on Kathak *hastas* and *thumris*. Add to this films, or even the ramp walk of fashion—his oeuvre is vast.

Born on February 4, 1938, to Pt Achchan Maharaj, the court dance talent of Rampur's *nawab*, Brij Mohan soon won many hearts and when his father passed away in 1947, he stepped into his shoes to take charge of his *gharana*. His uncles, Lachchu and Shambhu Maharaj, had already established themselves in Bombay and Lucknow, so for a young lad to prove himself and teach at Sangeet Bharati was a challenge that he rose to remarkably. At 14, he had arrived.

His long innings at the Shriram Bharatiya Kala Kendra were significant. He initially took the lead in Kendra productions of the 1950s, undertaking stellar roles in *Malati Madhav* (with Kumudini Lakhia), *Kumar Sambhav* and *Meghadootam*. Later, he lived in a Kendra flat behind the Kamani complex, with other greats of the time, like Ustad Munawar Ali Khan, Guru Mayadhar Raut, Guru K. Shekharan Panikar and Guru Kishan Chand Nayak. This placed him squarely at the centre of all activity. By then, the Sangeet Natak Akademi had created its first constituent body, the Kathak Kendra, to teach Kathak systematically, and Pt Birju Maharaj was a pillar for the Lucknow style. Gurus Sundar Prasad, Devi and Durga Lal were there for Jaipur and, later, Guru Kundan Lal. The history of Kathak Kendra is interlaced with Pt Birju Maharaj, so much so that in the 1990s it was felt that his towering personality had eclipsed other styles. Alas for the Jaipur *gharana*, most of its stalwarts died young.

He did stride high. Look at his oeuvre—memorable dance drama productions for Kathak Kendra like *Shan-e-Oudh* (music by Ustad Amjad Ali Khan and songs by Shanti Vaidyanathan-Sharma), one production on Wajid Ali Shah (with Pradeep Shankar as Wajid) and *Krishnayan*. Films beckoned, like Satyajit Ray's *Shatranj ke Khilari*, for which he created authentic dance sequences, and *Devdas* and *Bajirao Mastani*, in more recent years. He did international tours and had students across the world. Many awards and titles, including the highest civilian Padma Vibhushan, came his way.

Pt Birju Maharaj was not only a pillar of the Lucknow *gharana* of Kathak, but he also made the classical dance form contemporary without sacrificing tradition

His contributions to Indian dance have been many—first, *purush ang*, or the male dance form; second, making Kathak contemporary without sacrificing tradition; third, connecting classical dance to Bollywood; and, above all else, the art of the soloist in his heyday. Finally, a guru is known by his *shishyas* and these are legion, spread over three generations and more. While seniors like Bharati Gupta, Brojen Mukherjee, Arjun Mishra and Saswati Sen absorbed his *ang* most, many benefitted from even a cursory association with him, such was his magic and influence. His own institution, Kala Ashram, has been run successfully by Saswati over the past three decades. His outreach and impact are universal.

JUST A LOOK Pt Birju Maharaj performing the *navrasas* (nine emotions)

Pt Birju Maharaj was a genial, soft, kind man—like Krishna. Lovable, likeable. His ancestral home in Lucknow became a museum, courtesy the Uttar Pradesh government, and his houses in Delhi became *addas* for Kathak. Whenever I dropped in for a visit, he ensured we spent quality time together, discussing art, never him. 'Mithaas' (sweetness) could have been his second name—Birju Mithaas.

India has lost its last giant in dance. It is a huge loss, but wherever he is, his shy, childlike smile is telling us, "I'm busy creating an Indra Sabha in Vaikuntha." The only jewellery he wore was a Sai baba ring. That hand blessed so many. He has merged with his maker. Long live the King of Kathak! ■

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